China's rise has defined the last decade more than anything else. It is worth rehearsing some economic comparisons to see just how dramatic the shift has been. From 2009 to 2019, China's economy grew at an average of 7.84 per cent while India's economy grew at an average of 6.84 per cent. In the same period, the US grew at an average of just 1.84 per cent. In 2009, China's GDP was $5.1 trillion, India's was $1.24 trillion, and the US's was $14.44 trillion. By 2019, China stood at $14.34 trillion, India at $2.87 trillion, and the US at $21.42 trillion. In eleven years, China added $9.24 trillion, India added $1.53 trillion, and the US added $7.98 trillion to their GDPs. In 2009, China was roughly $9 trillion smaller than the US economy; in 2019, it had reduced the gap to $7 trillion. For India, in 2009, the gap with China was $3.76 trillion; by 2019, it had grown to a gargantuan $11.47 trillion. In sum, the gap between China and the US reduced, but the gap between China and India grew massively. India was within shooting distance of China in 2009; by 2019, China was out of sight. Russia, meanwhile, went from a GDP of $1.45 trillion in 2009 to just $1.76 trillion in 2019, which made it slightly bigger than South Korea.[40]

Not surprisingly, India and the US grew their partnership during this period. The pace of summits increased, with the top leaderships meeting almost every year until Trump came to office. A raft of dialogues began – economic, military, cybersecurity, and the so-called '2 plus 2' (defence and foreign policy). In 2010, President Obama endorsed India's claim to permanent membership of the UN Security Council – which left only China among the P-5 refusing to go along. By 2016, Washington had designated India as a major defence partner so that it would enjoy access to US defence technology reserved for treaty allies. Between 2002 and 2020, India signed four so-called foundational defence agreements with the US to enhance information, communication, intelligence, and logistics cooperation. American arms sales increased steadily, with India buying cargo and transport aircraft, attack helicopters, missiles, artillery, and torpedoes since 2008. In 2020, the US authorized total defence trade of $20 billion, in that year alone.[41] India–US trade overall boomed, rising from $37 billion in